

Marketing Strategy Playbook

A practical guide your AI Mentor can use to diagnose, write, and improve marketing strategies for fashion brands.

What this PDF is for

- Teach founders the difference between a **strategy** (choices) and a **plan** (calendar + tasks).
- Help the mentor AI **analyze** a user's current strategy and identify the bottleneck.
- Provide **templates**, **checklists**, and **examples** that produce a usable strategy in one session.
- Prevent random tactics (boosting posts, influencer spam, discounts) from replacing actual strategy.

How to use it (AI Mentor mode)

- Ask 8-12 questions first (Section 3). Don't write a strategy blind.
- Diagnose in this order: **Problem → Audience → Offer → Channel → Proof → Measurement**.
- Output: a one-page strategy + a 14-day action plan.
- If inputs are weak, say so and request missing info instead of guessing.

1) Strategy vs plan vs tactics

Most brands confuse activity with direction. This section forces the distinction.

Term	Definition	Good example	Bad example
Strategy	Your choices: who you target, what you sell, where you show up, and what you won't do.	We target college men in Cairo; hero product is heavyweight tees; Instagram + WhatsApp; no wholesale this quarter.	"We'll try everything: reels, ads, influencers, discounts, pop-ups."
Plan	The calendar: what happens this week/day to execute the strategy.	Post 5 reels/week; 2 WhatsApp broadcasts/week; 1 drop every 3 weeks; weekly KPI review.	A schedule with no clear target/offer; busy work.
Tactics	Single actions inside the plan.	Try-on reel; UGC repost; bundle offer; abandoned cart message.	Boost random posts; copy competitor discount; buy followers.

Ruthless mentor note

- If a founder says "my strategy is posting daily," they have **no strategy**. That's a tactic.
- A real strategy includes a list of what you will **not** do this month.

2) When you need a marketing strategy

You need a strategy when you're spending time or money and don't know what is actually driving sales.

You 100% need a strategy if any of these are true

- Sales are inconsistent (random spikes, then nothing).
- You post a lot but don't convert (views without orders).
- You run ads but can't explain why they work or don't.
- You're discounting often and margins are getting crushed.
- You want to scale (more SKUs, bigger budget, retail) and need alignment.

You can postpone a full strategy (for now) only if

- You're pre-launch and still validating the product + audience.
- You have **one** clear channel that is already reliably working and you're repeating it.
- You're doing a small test drop and learning fast (with tracking).

Ruthless mentor note: if your brand is "stuck," the issue is almost always positioning or offer clarity - not that you need a new tactic.

3) The AI Mentor's input checklist (minimum required)

Before writing a strategy, collect these inputs. If the user can't answer, the strategy must be framed as hypotheses + tests.

Input	What "good" looks like	If missing, the AI should do this
Target customer	Specific segment + location + income + style identity	Force a primary segment; park the rest
Problem / desire	One sentence (e.g., "looks expensive, feels heavy, fits tall guys")	Ask for 3-5 real buyer quotes (DMs/reviews)
Offer	Products + price range + why now + guarantee/urgency	Draft an offer statement and define a test
Competitors	3-5 real alternatives customers choose instead	Map differentiation + proof points
Channel reality	Where customers already spend time (IG/TikTok/WhatsApp/retail)	Pick one primary channel based on reality
Unit economics	COGS, gross margin, shipping, returns, CAC target	Use conservative assumptions + protect margin
Capacity	Ability to produce + deliver + respond (ops)	Recommend drops, pre-orders, or MOQ strategy
Goals	One measurable goal per stage	Convert vague goals to numbers + deadlines

High-signal questions (ask these first)

- What product do you sell, at what price, and what's the gross margin %?
- Who bought from you before? Why did they buy? (real words from DMs/reviews)
- What's your #1 bottleneck: low views, low clicks, low conversion, or low repeat?
- Where do your buyers spend time daily: Instagram, TikTok, WhatsApp, retail?
- What can you reliably produce and deliver per week without quality drops?

4) Diagnosis framework (the order matters)

Do not start with ads. Start with fundamentals. The fastest fix is usually upstream.

Step	What you are solving	What “strong” looks like	Common failure
Problem	What tension/desire creates demand?	One clear desire + proof it exists	Vague: “streetwear brand”
Audience	Who feels it most and will pay?	One sharp segment + context	Everyone / “youth”
Offer	What is the hero product + deal?	Clear hero, price, reason now, risk reversal	Too many SKUs / no reason to buy now
Channel	Where do they discover + decide?	1 primary + 1 secondary with roles	Posting everywhere with no role
Proof	Why should they believe you?	UGC, reviews, fit details, behind-the-scenes	Claims only
Measurement	How do you know it’s working?	KPIs + targets + weekly review	No numbers, only feelings

Bottleneck rule

- Low views → your hooks/format are weak. Fix content, not ads.
- High views, low clicks → your offer/positioning is unclear. Fix messaging + CTA.
- Clicks, low sales → product page, pricing, trust, or sizing is broken.
- Sales, no repeat → quality, expectations, or customer experience is broken.

5) Channel strategy logic (how the AI should decide)

A channel is chosen for where your buyers already are and how fast you need feedback - not because it's popular.

Channel	Best for	Weak for	Success signal
Instagram	Aesthetic + proof + community	Cold discovery without Reels/Collabs	Saves, profile visits, DMs
TikTok	Cold discovery via raw storytelling	Over-polished ads-style content	Watch time, shares, comments
WhatsApp	Conversion + retention	Top-of-funnel discovery	Reply rate, orders per broadcast
Website	Scale + brand trust	Conversion if product page is weak	CVR, AOV, refund rate
Retail pop-up	Trust + trial + UGC	Profit if footfall is low	Unit sales/day, new contacts
Wholesale	Volume + reach	Margins + brand control	Reorder rate, sell-through
Marketplaces	Fast demand + logistics	Brand building	Ranking, repeat, margin after fees

AI mentor: diagnose channel mismatch

- If they sell premium but only post price-based content → mismatch.
- If they want fast growth but only do slow organic posting → mismatch.
- If they run paid but don't have a conversion-ready page → mismatch.
- If they do wholesale with weak ops/quality consistency → mismatch.

6) Strategy by stage (fashion brand reality)

Stage	Primary goal	Best strategies	Common mistake
Pre-launch	Validate demand + build waitlist	Founder story + community + small product tests	Buying followers / running ads with no offer
Launch / Drop	Convert attention into orders	Hero product + urgency + social proof + clear CTA	Too many SKUs; no clear hero
Post-launch	Improve margin + repeat	Retention content + WhatsApp + bundles + reviews	Discounting to “fix” a weak product
Scale	Systemize growth	Creative testing + predictable paid + ops systems	Scaling spend before fixing conversion

Stage rule (don't break this)

- Pre-launch: prove demand **cheaply** (content + community) before paid.
- Launch: keep focus. One hero product and one primary channel.
- Post-launch: protect margin. Fix experience and retention.
- Scale: paid is an amplifier - it punishes weak fundamentals.

7) Measurement and KPIs that matter

If you do not measure, you cannot improve. Track the minimum set that tells you if promotion is working.

Area	Metric	Why it matters	Healthy direction
Content	Saves/share rate	Signal of value and distribution	Up
Traffic	Link CTR	Whether content drives action	Up
Store	Conversion rate (CVR)	Page trust and offer clarity	Up
Ads	CPA	Cost to acquire customer	Down
Ads	ROAS / MER	Efficiency (channel vs total)	Up
Retention	Repeat purchase rate	Brand strength	Up

Weekly review ritual (non-negotiable)

- Pick 3 KPIs for the week. Set targets (numbers).
- Run 5-10 creative tests/week. Kill losers fast.
- Write 3 learning notes: what worked, what failed, what to change.

8) AI mentor scoring rubric (stress test a strategy)

Use this to grade the user's strategy and tell them exactly what is weak.

Area	0-2 (weak)	3-4 (ok)	5 (strong)
Target	Too broad / unclear	Some segmentation	One sharp segment + proof
Positioning	Generic	Some differentiation	Unique + believable + desired
Offer	Just a product	Offer exists but fuzzy	Clear hero, urgency, guarantee
Channels	Everywhere	Two channels but unclear roles	Primary + secondary with roles
Proof	Claims only	Some proof	UGC/reviews/detail shots + story
Measurement	No numbers	Tracks some metrics	KPIs + targets + weekly review

Ruthless mentor rule

- If Target + Positioning + Offer are weak, **do not** recommend paid ads.
- If conversion is weak, **do not** recommend "more followers."
- If margins are thin, **do not** recommend heavy discounts.
- A strategy must include what you will **not** do this month.

9) Outputs the AI should produce

Deliverables should be simple enough to execute, but strict enough to create focus.

Section	What to fill	Example (fashion brand)
Target	Who exactly + where + income + style	College men in Cairo who want premium basics
Problem / desire	One sentence	They want tees that look expensive and last
Positioning	Why you vs alternatives	Heavyweight, clean fit, premium feel at mid price
Hero offer	Hero SKU + price + reason now + guarantee	Heavyweight tee @ 650 EGP; limited drop; free exchange
Channels	Primary + secondary roles	IG = discovery/proof; WhatsApp = conversion/retention
Proof plan	What proof you will publish	Try-ons, reviews, fabric close-ups, BTS production
KPIs	3-5 weekly metrics	Saves rate, CTR, CVR, CPA, repeat %

14-day action plan (minimum)

- Week 1: Publish 5 reels (hooks + proof). Collect 20 DM questions. Fix product page basics.
- Week 2: Run 2 WhatsApp broadcasts. Launch micro-drop. Track CVR + refund rate + repeat intent.
- End of day 14: decide **one** thing to double down on and **one** thing to stop.

10) Worksheets (fill-in-the-blank)

Use these as a fast way to write a coherent strategy in one session.

A) **Positioning:** For *[target]*, *[brand]* is the *[category]* that *[benefit]* because *[proof]*.

B) **Offer:** Buy *[hero]* for *[price]*. Get *[bundle/bonus]*. Risk reversal: *[guarantee]*. Urgency: *[reason now]*.

C) **Channel roles:** *[Primary]* = discovery + proof. *[Secondary]* = conversion + retention.

D) **KPI targets:** Saves rate *[x%]*, CTR *[x%]*, CVR *[x%]*, Repeat *[x%]*, Return rate *[x%]*.

Final mentor punch

- A strategy is not “post more.” A strategy is **who, why, what, where**, and **how we measure**.
- If the user keeps changing direction weekly, they are not doing marketing. They are doing gambling.